

My name is Anthony Fenech.

I'm a procrastinator. That's probably the first thing you should know about me.

It's New Year's Eve, around noon, I'm listening to Lynyrd Skynyrd's Free Bird, and I guess you could say I'm just winging it.

The second is, I'm broke. As hell. I lived in Vegas for nine months, gambled too much there, went to Pittsburgh for the summer, didn't get paid a cent, and now I'm getting paid in peanuts at the school paper – borrowing money from my mom, who is borrowing money from my aunt, which is putting a strain on everybody – all the while supporting one fantasy sports addiction and two tobacco addictions.

The third is I'm going to be an intern your paper next summer.

And I say that with the least bit of confidence, as I continue to get rejected left-and-right, so stricken for words to sell myself to my favorite newspaper that I've resorted to a stolen line from the cover letter that landed me my first writing internship.

But I also say that with the most bit of confidence, because Free Bird skipped out before the guitar solo about ten minutes ago, I'm still cruising and I think this is a pretty good personal essay if I might say so myself.

Growing up in a Detroit suburb, I never wanted to write, I always wanted to play. But I could read at an early age, read a lot, and these days, I know those fake newspapers I drew up meant something.

In high school, I didn't mature; I kept a journal about girls, got in trouble and played sports. A few days after my 17th birthday, I got busted for drinking and had to do community service. There, I dusted and arranged bookshelves, came across a compilation book of Mitch Albom columns and that was that.

I befriended a family friend named Matt Fiorito, an editor and bowling columnist at the Detroit Free Press, and he taught me how to be a journalist.

My first internship was unpaid at a radio station at age 18 while I took night classes at a community college.

The one thing I learned during that internship was that I was going to be a writer.

At 19, Matt got me an interview at the Free Press. I've worked there ever since and I'm live-blogging the Gator Bowl tomorrow. It will probably be on the front page and amongst the most read stories on the website. Just saying.

At 20, I got drunk, drove, and rolled my car going 75 mph on the freeway. I totaled my car. I broke my wrist, playing baseball of course, and took the bus to work the rest of the summer.

Without a car, I went up to Central Michigan University, worked two jobs, walked for miles in the blistering cold to the post office and back mailing out internship applications, seethed as all of my classmates got those internships, kept believing in my substituted Lil' Wayne lyric reminding the world that "The next time you mention Mitch, Tony or Plasch-ke, don't forget about Fenech ba-by!" and ended up in Vegas.

In Vegas, I bought a silver 2002 Ford Taurus with the money I saved, and while writing over 150 by-lined stories at the Las Vegas Sun, lived out of that car while bouncing from stays with an anal-retentive family, a cheating couple and a columnist. On my 22nd birthday, I covered two games, wrote a feature, went to the Palms and, in learning from my previous lesson, woke up in my car the next day.

In May, I drove it to Pittsburgh and challenged myself to become a better reporter, working outside of a sports arena for the first time in my life at the Pittsburgh Post-Gazette. I did, spent the last dollar of my bank account in the middle of July, learned a lot about my craft and most importantly, myself, and the lengths to which I'll go to succeed.

These days, I'm a 23-year-old, sixth-year junior at CMU that's a lot closer to dropping out than graduating.

I sit in classes that I'll eventually fail, daydreaming about catching those dreams, and I spend my time working on turning those journals I used to write into a novel.

I'm being a complete idiot, of course, but I know that through my experience, I have the tools, talent and mental toughness to thrive in this industry.

I care about people, I know how to talk to people, I can report, and I can write the hell out of what I report. I'll work all day, I'll work all night, I'll work for free and I'll work for credits that I have to pay for with the money I don't have, all for my passion and pride.

I've wrote cover letters in first-person, in third-person; I've penned stories about wanting another night in Boston and taking my talents to South Beach, and yet, here I am, a half-hour from The UPS Store closing, a dream on a deadline, and I think I've finally said what I've needed to say all along:

My name is Anthony Fenech and I deserve the opportunity to work for your newspaper.

